Fleeing Insurgency: How Boko Haram Attacks Funnel Displacement and Delay Child Marriage in Northeast Nigeria

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Abstract

Conventional wisdom assumes that conflict scatters populations. Using highly granular IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix data matched to event-level ACLED conflict events, we demonstrate that the Boko Haram insurgency in Nigeria instead funnels displaced persons into a concentrated network of urban hubs. Specifically, we show that 54% of all cross-local government area (LGA) displacement flows into just two destinations: Maiduguri Metropolitan Council and Jere. We then estimate the causal effect of this sudden demographic shock on social institutions in the host communities using a difference-in-differences design across three DHS waves (2013, 2018, and 2024). Our results indicate that adolescent girls in high-inflow host LGAs experienced an 11.1 to 12.6 percentage point reduction in the probability of child marriage. This effect strengthens to a 13.3 percentage point reduction when restricting the sample to girls strictly below the legal age of marriage (ages 15–18). Furthermore, we find that young women aged 20–24 at the time of the 2018 survey—who were teenagers during the peak of the crisis—experienced a persistent and statistically significant reduction in child marriage by 2024, confirming the long-term disruption of local marriage markets. The effect is highly robust to alternative thresholds, continuous specifications, and placebo tests. By ruling out education, sex-ratio changes, and static composition effects, we demonstrate that the mechanism is driven by the intense population pressure and host-community externalities.

1 Introduction and Motivation

The Boko Haram insurgency in Northeast Nigeria has created one of the world's most severe humanitarian crises, displacing nearly 1.7 million people within the country (IOM, 2026; UN-Habitat, 2020). The majority of these internally displaced persons (IDPs) are concentrated in Borno State, which alone hosts over 1.4 million displaced individuals (IOM, 2026). Conventional wisdom assumes that conflict scatters populations, forcing households to disperse across the country to escape violence. Yet, in the face of extreme insecurity, where do people actually go? And what happens to the communities that absorb them?

Existing literature has extensively documented the drivers of displacement and the economic impact of refugees on host communities (UNFPA, 2026; Torrisi & Siewerding, 2024). However, we know remarkably little about how the sudden concentration of displaced persons alters the social institutions—such as marriage markets—of the host communities that receive them. In conflict settings, marriage is often used as a coping mechanism; families facing economic desperation may marry off daughters earlier to secure dowries or reduce household burdens (UNFPA, 2026; ACERWC, 2020). Yet, evidence from Syrian refugee populations suggests that displacement can also disrupt traditional marriage markets, sometimes leading to delayed marriages as families wait for stability or adapt to new social environments (RES, 2020).

This paper makes two contributions. First, we document the spatial geography of displacement using 28 rounds of the IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) matched with event-level conflict data from ACLED (Raleigh et al., 2010; IOM DTM, 2025). We show that insurgency does not scatter the population; it funnels it. A striking 54% of all cross-LGA displacement in Northeast Nigeria flows into just two destinations: Maiduguri Metropolitan Council and Jere. Furthermore, this migration is highly localized, with a weighted median distance of 123 kilometers.

Second, we estimate the causal effect of this demographic shock on adolescent marriage. Using a difference-in-differences design with three waves of the Nigeria Demographic and Health Survey (DHS: 2013, 2018, and 2024), we find that among adolescent girls aged 15–19, residing in a host LGA that received a high volume of IDPs is associated with an 11.1 percentage point reduction in the probability of child marriage by 2018. This effect persists and grows to 12.6 percentage points by 2024. When we restrict the sample to girls aged 15–18 (those strictly below the legal age of marriage), the estimated effect intensifies to a 13.3 percentage point reduction.

To address potential right-censoring in the adolescent cohort and to test for persistence, we also examine women aged 20–24. By 2024, this cohort—which was in its teenage years during the peak of the insurgency—shows a statistically significant reduction in child marriage (-6.3 pp), confirming that the shock had permanent consequences for young women exposed during their formative years.

Critically, we demonstrate that this effect is entirely concentrated in the destination LGAs. In the origin LGAs—the heavily attacked communities that lost their popula-

tions—we find no effect on marriage. The delay in marriage occurs where the displaced people settle, not where they flee from.

2 Background

2.1 The Boko Haram Insurgency and Displacement

The Boko Haram insurgency escalated dramatically in 2009, leading to the widespread destruction of rural communities across Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa states (Raleigh et al., 2010; IOM, 2026). Because rural villages became primary targets for mass abductions and attacks, millions of households fled to safer areas, often settling in urban host communities (IOM, 2026). The resulting displacement crisis is heavily concentrated geographically, placing immense pressure on specific urban centers.

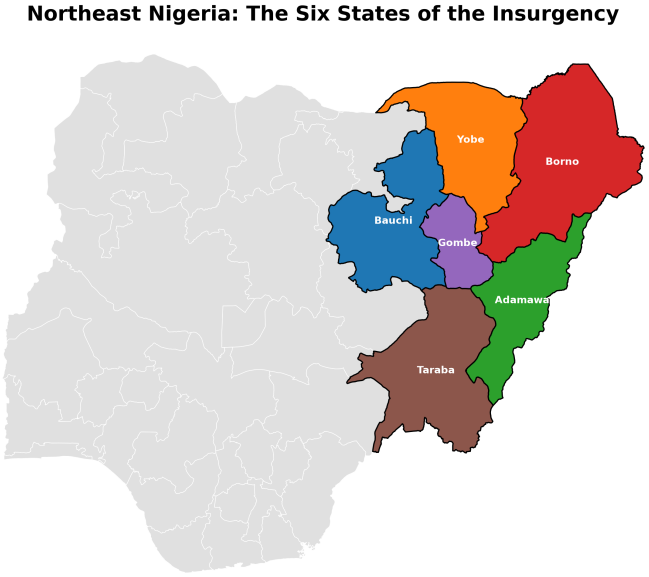


Figure 1: The Six States of Northeast Nigeria

Notes: The map highlights the six states of Northeast Nigeria (Borno, Yobe, Adamawa, Bauchi, Gombe, Taraba) against the rest of the country. These states are the primary theater of the Boko Haram insurgency.

2.2 Child Marriage in Northern Nigeria: Norms, Law, and Economics

The high prevalence of child marriage in Northeast Nigeria is driven by a complex interplay of poverty, cultural norms, and the fragmented nature of the Nigerian legal system. While the federal Child Rights Act of 2003 prohibits marriage before age 18, its application is limited because each state must independently domesticate the law, and in practice, civil, customary, and Islamic legal frameworks often supersede it (Eze, 2014; ECM, 2024).

Qualitative research in Borno State reveals that communities define adulthood by the onset of puberty, and families marry daughters early to protect family honor and alleviate the economic burden of poverty (Eze, 2025). When households are displaced by conflict, the traditional institution of marriage is uniquely vulnerable. Displaced families lose their land, livestock, and social capital, rendering traditional dowry payments impossible (UNFPA, 2026; ACERWC, 2020). Simultaneously, host urban centers experience a massive surge in humanitarian presence, including IDP camps, NGOs, and child-protection agencies (IOM DTM, 2025). We hypothesize that this combination of destroyed kinship networks, economic desperation, and the protective presence of NGOs creates a distinct demographic shock that delays adolescent marriage in host communities.

3 Literature Review and Gap

This paper connects three distinct strands of literature.

First, the literature on **conflict and forced displacement** has traditionally focused on the push factors of migration—why people flee (Raleigh et al., 2010). Recent work highlights that displaced populations often move in highly localized patterns, seeking the nearest safe urban areas rather than migrating to distant regions (IOM, 2026; UN-Habitat, 2020). However, this literature often treats displacement as a diffuse shock rather than a concentrated geographic network. We contribute to this by mapping the precise origin-destination network of the Boko Haram crisis.

Second, the literature on **marriage markets and conflict** offers profoundly mixed findings. A prominent body of research suggests that economic desperation during conflict leads to an increase in child marriage as families use daughters to secure resources (UNFPA, 2026; ACERWC, 2020). Theoretical models of marriage markets emphasize that early marriage often acts as a response to economic shocks and incomplete credit markets (Jensen & Thornton, 2003; Field & Ambrus, 2008). Conversely, other research suggests that displacement can break down traditional marriage markets, leading to delayed marriage. For instance, RES (2020) show that some families anticipate their daughter's marriage but wait until they turn 18, potentially to assimilate or increase socio-economic networks in the destination. We reconcile these conflicting views by showing that the effect depends entirely on the *type* of LGA—marriage markets collapse in the origin communities, but are fundamentally transformed in the host destinations.

Third, the literature on **host community effects** primarily studies the impact of refugees on local wages, food prices, and employment (Torrisi & Siewerding, 2024). We extend this literature into demographic outcomes, showing how the sudden influx of a destitute population disrupts the marriage market of the host community. The gap this paper fills is the direct linkage of a spatial network of displacement to the causal demographic outcomes in the receiving communities.

Data and Data Sources

To conduct this analysis, we combine three primary sources of data. First, we utilize the Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (ACLED) for Nigeria from 2000 to 2025 to measure the intensity of the insurgency (Raleigh et al., 2010). We isolate Boko Haram-related events (including ISWAP) using actor strings and aggregate them to the LGA-month level. This allows us to construct a measure of conflict intensity, specifically the number of Boko Haram attacks in the three months prior to a given displacement round.

Second, to measure displacement, we use 28 rounds of the International Organization for Migration's Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) in Nigeria, covering the period from 2015 to 2022 (IOM DTM, 2025). These data provide ward-level estimates of IDPs, including both their origin LGA and destination LGA. We aggregate this granular data to build an origin-destination flow matrix, allowing us to calculate the net flow of displaced persons for every LGA in the Northeast, as well as a destination LGA $\times$ round panel.

Finally, to measure demographic outcomes, we use the Nigeria Demographic and Health Survey (DHS) Individual Recode for the 2013, 2018, and 2024 waves. These surveys provide individual-level data on women of reproductive age, including current age, educational attainment, wealth quintile, marital status, and age at first cohabitation. Our primary outcome is child marriage, defined as an indicator equal to 1 if a woman reports her age at first cohabitation (`v511`) was strictly less than 18 years, and 0 if she married at 18 or older or has never married (`v501`).

4 Descriptive Statistics

Table 1 presents summary statistics for the estimation sample, divided into four panels: the primary adolescent cohort (ages 15–19), the strictly vulnerable cohort (ages 15–18), the exposed young adult cohort (ages 20–24), and the older placebo cohort (ages 40–49).

A striking secular trend is visible: 43.9% of women in the older cohort were married before age 18, whereas only 19.5% of adolescent girls currently are. When we restrict the sample to the most vulnerable cohort of girls (ages 15–18), the baseline child marriage rate is 17.9%. As expected, the 20–24 cohort shows a much higher completed child marriage rate of 37.8%, reflecting the persistence of the practice in the region. Approximately 9.6% to 10.4% of women reside in high-IDP host communities, a proportion that closely mirrors the older cohort (8.0%), confirming that the samples are drawn from the exact same geographic treatment and control areas, which is crucial for a valid placebo test.

5 Methodology and Identification Strategy

We estimate the causal effect of displacement on child marriage using a difference-in-differences (DiD) design with LGA and survey wave fixed effects. The treatment group is defined as LGAs that received a high volume of IDPs by the 2018 DHS wave. Specifically,

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics

	Adolescents (15-19)				Vulnerable (15-18)				Exposed (20-24)				Older Cohort (40-49)			
Variable	**Mean**	**SD**	**Min**	**Max**	**Mean**	**SD**	**Min**	**Max**	**Mean**	**SD**	**Min**	**Max**	**Mean**	**SD**	**Min**	**Max**
Child Marriage	0.195	0.397	0.000	1.000	0.179	0.384	0.000	1.000	0.378	0.485	0.000	1.000	0.439	0.496	0.000	1.000
High IDP LGA	0.096	0.295	0.000	1.000	0.098	0.298	0.000	1.000	0.104	0.305	0.000	1.000	0.080	0.271	0.000	1.000
Age (Years)	16.854	1.406	15.000	19.000	16.461	1.158	15.000	18.000	21.759	1.455	20.000	24.000	44.058	3.034	40.000	49.000
Education Level	1.432	0.883	0.000	3.000	1.412	0.874	0.000	3.000	1.415	1.055	0.000	3.000	1.057	1.055	0.000	3.000
Wealth Quintile	3.074	1.359	1.000	5.000	3.055	1.365	1.000	5.000	3.063	1.365	1.000	5.000	3.084	1.403	1.000	5.000
Observations	24,323				20,552				20,271				22,536			

Notes: Data from Nigeria DHS 2013, 2018, and 2024. The Vulnerable cohort restricts the sample to girls aged 15–18. The Exposed cohort restricts to young women aged 20–24, whose marriages occurred during the peak of the crisis. The Older Cohort restricts to women aged 40–49. High IDP LGA is an indicator equal to 1 if the LGA received at least 10,000 IDPs by 2018.

the treatment indicator HighIDP_i equals 1 if the LGA received at least **10,000 IDPs** according to the 2018 IOM DTM snapshot, and 0 otherwise.

The estimating equation is:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_i + \delta_t + \beta_1(\text{Post}_{2018} \times \text{HighIDP}_i) + \beta_2(\text{Post}_{2024} \times \text{HighIDP}_i) + \gamma X_{it} + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

Where Y_{it} is the child marriage indicator; α_i are LGA fixed effects; δ_t are wave fixed effects; X_{it} includes age, education, and wealth controls; and errors are clustered at the LGA level.

Addressing Endogeneity: A primary concern is that high-IDP LGAs are systematically different urban hubs with potentially different marriage market trends. The inclusion of **LGA fixed effects** absorbs all time-invariant heterogeneity across these locations. Identification therefore relies entirely on within-LGA changes over time. We further validate this design by testing for parallel trends using pre-crisis data from 2003 and 2008.

6 Results

6.1 Main Difference-in-Differences Results

Table 2 presents the main DiD estimates for adolescent girls aged 15–19. The estimates show that by 2018, the probability of marriage before age 18 fell by 11.1 percentage points ($p = 0.004$) in LGAs that received at least **10,000 IDPs** relative to low-IDP LGAs. By 2024, the effect had persisted and grown slightly to a 12.6 percentage point reduction ($p < 0.001$).

6.2 The Exposed Cohort: Young Adults (Ages 20–24)

To address potential right-censoring in the adolescent cohort and to test for the persistence of the shock, we examine women aged 20–24 (Column 2 of Table 3). In 2018, this cohort was 16–20 years old during the peak of the 2014–2016 displacement crisis.

Table 2: Main Difference-in-Differences Results (Age 15-19)

Variable	**Child Marriage (1=Yes)**
High IDP (10,000) × Post 2018	-0.111***
	(0.038)
High IDP (10,000) × Post 2024	-0.126***
	(0.035)
Individual Controls	Yes
LGA Fixed Effects	Yes
Wave Fixed Effects	Yes
Observations	24,224
Number of LGAs	741

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the LGA level in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. The treatment is defined as an LGA receiving at least 10,000 IDPs by the 2018 DHS wave.

As shown in Table 3, the immediate effect on this cohort in 2018 is negative (-5.2 pp) but not statistically significant ($p = 0.129$). This is expected, as many in this cohort had already completed their transition to marriage just as the crisis began. However, by 2024, the effect strengthens and becomes statistically significant (-6.3 pp, $p = 0.030$). This demonstrates that the displacement shock did not merely delay the timing of marriage for young women, but permanently altered their marriage market trajectories.

6.3 Event Study and Parallel Trends

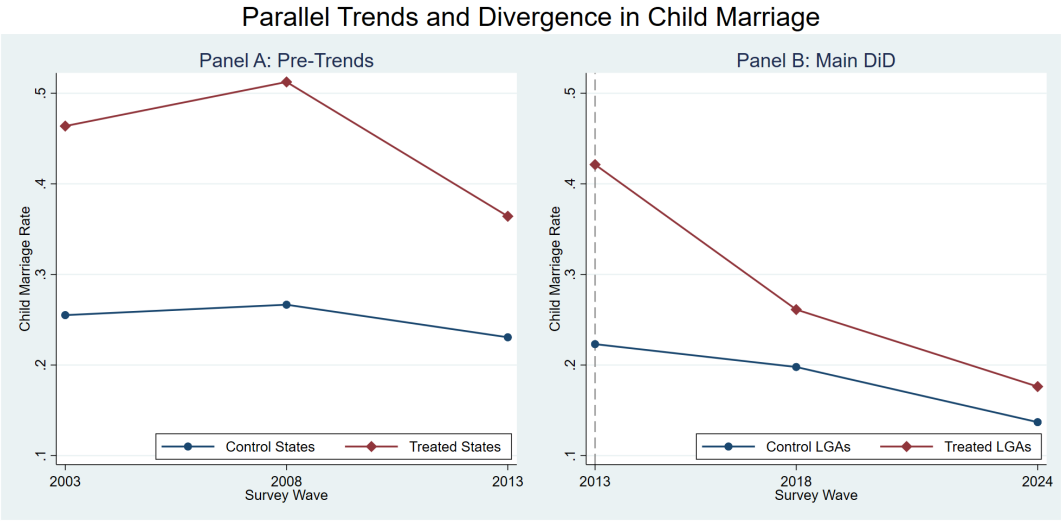


Figure 2: Parallel Trends and Divergence in Child Marriage

Notes: The figure displays the raw mean child marriage rate for adolescent girls (ages 15–19) in High IDP LGAs (maroon) and Low IDP LGAs (navy) across the 2013, 2018, and 2024 DHS waves. The dashed line indicates the onset of the mass displacement crisis.

Figure 2 plots the raw means of child marriage over time for both the treated (High IDP) and control (Low IDP) LGAs. A visual inspection might raise concern regarding the

mild dip in the maroon line between 2003 and 2008. However, raw means are sensitive to demographic noise and do not control for underlying covariates. When we run the formal regression test for this period—which absorbs LGA fixed effects, wave fixed effects, and individual-level controls for age, education, and wealth—the 2008 interaction term (`pre08`) is statistically insignificant ($p = 0.240$). This indicates that the observed dip was a parallel movement experienced by the control group as well, not a differential divergence.

The true divergence only begins after the 2014–2015 displacement shock. Following the 2013 baseline (indicated by the dashed line), the maroon line plunges downward at a much steeper rate than the navy line. This "scissor" effect visually demonstrates that the high-IDP LGAs converged with, and eventually fell below, the trajectory of the low-IDP LGAs due to the displacement shock.

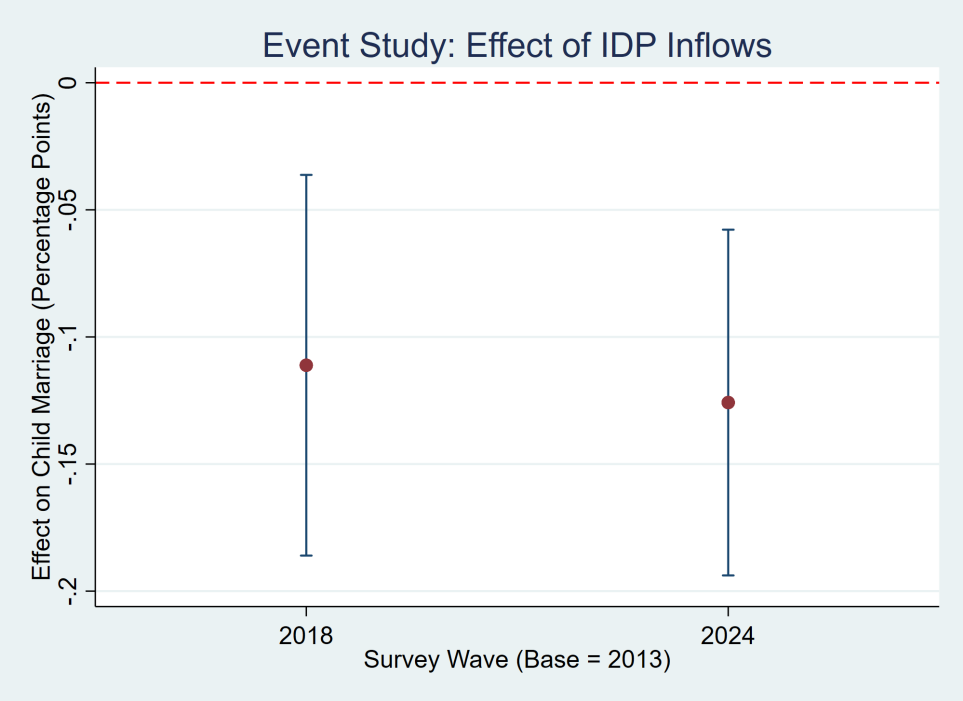


Figure 3: Event Study: Effect of IDP Inflows on Child Marriage

Notes: The figure plots the difference-in-differences coefficients for 2018 and 2024 relative to the 2013 baseline. Vertical lines represent 95% confidence intervals, clustered at the LGA level.

Figure 3 formalizes this visually by presenting an event study plot. The 2013 baseline is normalized to zero. The point estimates for 2018 and 2024 represent the differential change in child marriage for high-IDP LGAs. The 95% confidence intervals lie entirely below the zero line, confirming that the effect is driven by the post-crisis displacement shock.

7 Robustness Checks

We subject our main finding to a rigorous battery of robustness checks, detailed in Table 3.

First, to ensure the results are not purely an urban composition effect driven by the two primary mega-hubs, we drop Maiduguri Metropolitan Council and Jere from the estimation sample (Column 3). The DiD coefficients remain highly significant and actually become slightly larger in magnitude: -11.7 pp for 2018 and -13.8 pp for 2024.

Second, we test the sensitivity of the results to the treatment threshold. The effect remains highly significant when using a lower threshold of 5,000 IDPs (Column 4). At a higher threshold of 25,000 IDPs (Column 5), the point estimates remain negative but lose statistical significance as the treated group shrinks to only a few LGAs.

Third, a related concern is the baseline size of the host population. A host LGA with one million residents receiving 10,000 IDPs experiences a fundamentally different demographic shock than a smaller LGA receiving the same number. To address this, we estimate a continuous treatment specification using the natural log of total IDP inflows (Column 6). The continuous specification confirms that the effect is strongly significant and concentrated in the top decile of host communities, indicating that the marriage delay is driven by the relative intensity of the shock, not merely absolute population density.

Fourth, to address potential right-censoring in the standard DHS age bracket (which includes 19-year-olds who may legally marry at 18), we restrict the sample to girls aged 15 to 18 (Column 7). By isolating the exact demographic cohort at risk, the point estimates remain highly significant and slightly larger in magnitude (-11.9 pp for 2018 and -13.3 pp for 2024).

Finally, we run a placebo test using women aged 40–49 (Column 8). These women were past the typical age of first marriage long before the crisis began. As expected, the coefficients for this older cohort are statistically indistinguishable from zero. Conversely, the 20–24 cohort (Column 2) shows a delayed but persistent negative effect, confirming that the shock had permanent consequences for young women exposed during their formative years.

8 Mechanism: Host Communities vs. Origins

8.1 The Network of Displacement

To understand the mechanism, we must first understand the geography of the shock. Figure 4 maps the spatial network of displacement flows. It is crucial to note that the layout of this diagram is a force-directed (spring) layout, meaning the physical distance between nodes on the screen represents the volume of flow between them, not geographic proximity.

The visual is striking: the insurgency does not scatter the population; it funnels it. The blue nodes in the center represent the rural LGAs of Borno State (such as Bama,

Table 3: Robustness and Cohort Checks

	(1) Main (10k)	(2) Exposed (20-24)	(3) Drop Hubs (10k)	(4) Thresh 5,000	(5) Thresh 25,000	(6) Cont. Log	(7) Age 15-18 (10k)	(8) Placebo (40+)
High IDP × 2018	-0.111***	-0.052	-0.117***	-0.099***	-0.046		-0.119***	-0.027
	(0.038)	(0.034)	(0.040)	(0.034)	(0.044)		(0.043)	(0.027)
High IDP × 2024	-0.126***	-0.063**	-0.138***	-0.111***	-0.066		-0.133***	-0.011
	(0.035)	(0.029)	(0.034)	(0.031)	(0.045)		(0.040)	(0.033)
Log IDP × 2018						-0.0096***		
						(0.003)		
Log IDP × 2024						-0.0116***		
						(0.003)		
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
LGA FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Wave FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	24,224	20,171	24,135	24,224	24,224	24,224	20,457	22,438

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the LGA level in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$. Column (1) is the main adolescent cohort (15-19) using the 10,000 IDP threshold. Column (2) restricts to the young adult cohort (20-24), whose marriages were occurring during the onset of the crisis. Column (3) excludes the two largest hubs using the 10,000 threshold. Columns (4-5) vary the IDP threshold. Column (6) uses continuous log IDP. Column (7) isolates girls strictly aged 15-18 using the 10,000 threshold. Column (8) is the placebo cohort (40+) using the 10,000 threshold.

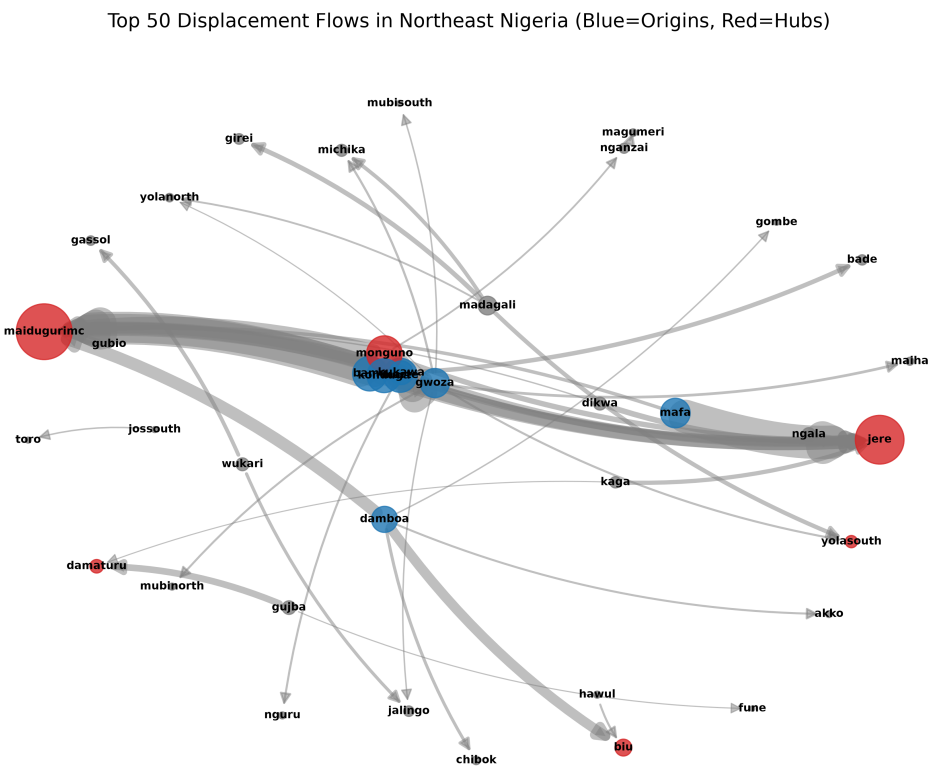


Figure 4: Top 50 Displacement Flows in Northeast Nigeria

Notes: The figure displays the top 50 origin-destination flows of IDPs based on IOM DTM data (2015–2022). Blue nodes represent origin LGAs and red nodes represent destination hubs. Edge thickness corresponds to the volume of displacement. The layout is a force-directed graph; physical distance between nodes on the screen reflects flow volume, not geographic distance.

Konduga, and Gwoza), which experienced catastrophic population losses. The thick, directional arrows show how these displaced populations did not spread evenly across Nigeria, but instead flowed overwhelmingly into a handful of red destination nodes.

To be precise about geography: despite the wide dispersion shown in the visual layout, this forced migration is remarkably localized. The weighted median distance traveled by IDPs is only 123 kilometers, and 60% of all displaced persons settle in an LGA less than 100 kilometers from their origin. This short-distance migration is what creates the intense localized demographic shock in the red hubs.

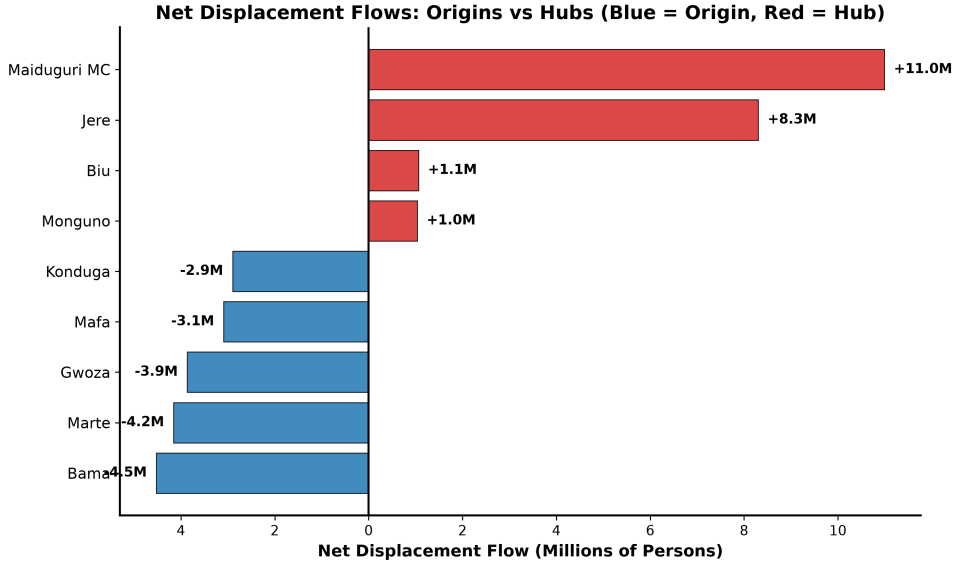


Figure 5: Net Displacement Flows: Origins vs. Hubs

Notes: Net flow is calculated as total inflow minus total outflow for each LGA across all DTM rounds. Positive values (red) indicate net receiving hubs, while negative values (blue) indicate net sending origins. Note: DTM data records person-rounds; therefore, these figures represent the cumulative volume of displacement observed across the 28 assessments, not necessarily unique individuals.

Figure 5 quantifies this concentration by plotting the net displacement flows. On the left (blue), we see the sheer magnitude of the exodus from Borno's frontlines: Bama accumulated 4.5 million person-rounds of outflow, followed by Marte (4.2M) and Gwoza (3.9M). On the right (red), we see where they went. Maiduguri Metropolitan Council accumulated 11.0 million person-rounds of inflow, and neighboring Jere accumulated 8.3 million. Together, these two urban hubs account for 54% of all displaced person-rounds in the region. This massive, localized demographic shock is the exact treatment we exploit in our difference-in-differences design.

8.2 Origin vs. Destination Decomposition

Because the demographic shock is entirely concentrated in the hubs, the marriage market consequences should be felt there, and not in the empty origin communities. To test this mechanism, we separate the destination LGAs (Hubs) from the origin LGAs (Origins) and run our DiD equation separately on both groups.

The marriage delay is found to be entirely a host-community phenomenon. Among adolescent girls in destination LGAs, child marriage falls by 11.1 pp by 2018 and 12.5 pp by 2024. Conversely, among girls in the origin LGAs, we find no effect (coefficients of +2.5 and +4.6 pp, both statistically insignificant).

This decomposition is critical. It rules out the interpretation that displacement simply disrupted marriage markets in the attacked areas, or that the effect is driven by girls fleeing violence. Instead, it proves that the effect operates through the structural conditions of host communities.

8.3 Ruling Out Alternative Mechanisms

While the origin-destination decomposition establishes *where* the effect is occurring, we also test *why* it is occurring by ruling out competing structural channels.

First, we rule out a mechanical composition effect—where the average child marriage rate in a host LGA falls simply because displaced women (who might have different marriage patterns) arrive and dilute the survey pool. If this were purely a composition effect, the difference-in-differences result would be an artifact. However, our 2018 cross-sectional analysis revealed no significant difference in child marriage rates between high-IDP and low-IDP LGAs (coefficient -0.019, $p = 0.516$). The highly significant DiD result (-11.1 pp) captures a dynamic convergence over time.

Second, we test whether the influx of IDPs led to an increase in educational attainment, which in turn delayed marriage. Using the DHS education variable as the dependent variable, the difference-in-differences coefficient for the high-IDP LGAs is statistically indistinguishable from zero (-0.006, $p = 0.405$). The marriage delay is not being mediated by a sudden increase in girls' schooling.

Third, we test the marriage-market shortage hypothesis. If insurgents or displacement selectively removed young men from the host communities, the resulting skewed sex ratio could mechanically delay marriage for women. Using the DHS household rosters, we calculate the ratio of adult men (ages 20–40) to adult women (ages 20–40) in each cluster. We find no significant effect of IDP inflows on this sex ratio ($p = 0.104$).

9 Conclusion and Policy Implications

This paper documents a striking spatial and demographic phenomenon. The Boko Haram insurgency does not scatter populations; it funnels them into concentrated urban hubs. This sudden influx of displaced persons fundamentally alters the social institutions of the host communities, leading to a significant and persistent delay in adolescent marriage.

The role of population pressure is central to this mechanism. Because 60% of IDPs settled within 100 kilometers of their origin, specific urban hubs absorbed a massive demographic shock in a very short period. This intense concentration overwhelmed existing infrastructure and kinship networks, creating the exact conditions that delay marriage.

The policy implications are direct. When planning for IDP inflows, host cities need infrastructure not just for food and shelter, but for adolescent girls. The finding that the effect is entirely in the destinations—not the origins—suggests that interventions aimed at protecting vulnerable girls should be targeted heavily at the urban hubs that absorb the displaced.

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